ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Reported questions and commands

Report questions, requests and commands with statement word order, appropriate backshift and infinitive patterns. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use reported questions and commands to retell an interaction without preserving direct-question inversion or quotation form while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Report questions, requests and commands with statement word order, appropriate backshift and infinitive patterns.

MODEL

She asked whether the figures had been verified.

ask + wh/if + subject + verb | tell/ask + object + to-infinitive

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main reported questions and commands patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses retell an interaction without preserving direct-question inversion or quotation form.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in interviews, minutes, narratives and customer-service reports.

Build meaning before form

Report questions, requests and commands with statement word order, appropriate backshift and infinitive patterns.

What reported questions and commands communicates

Report questions, requests and commands with statement word order, appropriate backshift and infinitive patterns.

The central purpose is to retell an interaction without preserving direct-question inversion or quotation form. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.	the content of an information question
She asked whether the figures had been verified.	the content of a yes-or-no question
The officer told us to remain outside.	an instruction or request directed at a person

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: ask + wh/if + subject + verb | tell/ask + object + to-infinitive. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “She asked whether the figures had been verified.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Reported wh-question	ask + wh-word + subject + verb	He asked why the delivery had been delayed.
Reported yes/no question	ask + if/whether + subject + verb	She asked whether the figures had been verified.
Reported command	tell/ask + object + to-infinitive	The officer told us to remain outside.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
the content of an information question	Reported wh-question
the content of a yes-or-no question	Reported yes/no question
an instruction or request directed at a person	Reported command

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in interviews, minutes, narratives and customer-service reports. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06	07
ask	wh/if	subject	verb	tell/ask	object	to-infinitive

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: retell an interaction without preserving direct-question inversion or quotation form.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits interviews, minutes, narratives and customer-service reports.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Reported wh-question	ask + wh-word + subject + verb	He asked why the delivery had been delayed.
Reported yes/no question	ask + if/whether + subject + verb	She asked whether the figures had been verified.
Reported command	tell/ask + object + to-infinitive	The officer told us to remain outside.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.	the content of an information question
She asked whether the figures had been verified.	the content of a yes-or-no question
The officer told us to remain outside.	an instruction or request directed at a person

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not retain subject-auxiliary inversion in a reported question.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use that to introduce a reported yes-or-no question.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not omit the object after tell in this pattern.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the content of an information question?

OPTIONS He asked why the delivery had been delayed. · She asked whether the figures had been verified. · The officer told us to remain outside.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the content of a yes-or-no question?

OPTIONS She asked whether the figures had been verified. · The officer told us to remain outside. · He asked why the delivery had been delayed.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an instruction or request directed at a person?

OPTIONS The officer told us to remain outside. · He asked why the delivery had been delayed. · She asked whether the figures had been verified.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “He asked why the delivery had been delayed.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the content of an information question · the content of a yes-or-no question · an instruction or request directed at a person

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “She asked whether the figures had been verified.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the content of a yes-or-no question · an instruction or request directed at a person · the content of an information question

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The officer told us to remain outside.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an instruction or request directed at a person · the content of an information question · the content of a yes-or-no question

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“He asked why the delivery had been delayed.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Reported wh-question / Reported yes/no question / Reported command · Gap 2: the content of an information question / the content of a yes-or-no question / an instruction or request directed at a person

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“She asked whether the figures had been verified.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Reported yes/no question / Reported command / Reported wh-question · Gap 2: the content of a yes-or-no question / an instruction or request directed at a person / the content of an information question

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The officer told us to remain outside.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Reported command / Reported wh-question / Reported yes/no question · Gap 2: an instruction or request directed at a person / the content of an information question / the content of a yes-or-no question

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses the content of an information question: _____. Choose the model that expresses the content of a yes-or-no question: _____. Choose the model that expresses an instruction or request directed at a person: _____. Choose the model built with ask + wh-word + subject + verb: _____. Choose the model built with ask + if/whether + subject + verb: _____. Choose the model built with tell/ask + object + to-infinitive: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

He asked why the delivery had been delayed. · She asked whether the figures had been verified. · The officer told us to remain outside.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

04 · PRACTICE STAGE

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

He asked _____. She asked _____. The officer _____ outside. State the full structural pattern for Reported wh-question: _____. State the full structural pattern for Reported yes/no question: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “He asked, “Why was the delivery delayed?”” using the Reported wh-question pattern to express the content of an information question.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “She asked, “Have the figures been verified?”” using the Reported yes/no question pattern to express the content of a yes-or-no question.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The officer said, “Remain outside.”” using the Reported command pattern to express an instruction or request directed at a person.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “He asked, “Why was the delivery delayed?”” using the Reported wh-question pattern to express the content of an information question.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Reported wh-question to express the content of an information question, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Reported yes/no question to express the content of a yes-or-no question, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Reported command to express an instruction or request directed at a person, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.

Reported wh-question is the best match because the content of an information question.

A2

She asked whether the figures had been verified.

Reported yes/no question is the best match because the content of a yes-or-no question.

A3

The officer told us to remain outside.

Reported command is the best match because an instruction or request directed at a person.

A4

the content of an information question

The Reported wh-question pattern communicates the content of an information question.

A5

the content of a yes-or-no question

The Reported yes/no question pattern communicates the content of a yes-or-no question.

A6

an instruction or request directed at a person

The Reported command pattern communicates an instruction or request directed at a person.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Reported wh-question / the content of an information question

The structure belongs to the Reported wh-question pattern. Its communicative purpose is the content of an information question.

B2

Reported yes/no question / the content of a yes-or-no question

The structure belongs to the Reported yes/no question pattern. Its communicative purpose is the content of a yes-or-no question.

B3

Reported command / an instruction or request directed at a person

The structure belongs to the Reported command pattern. Its communicative purpose is an instruction or request directed at a person.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.

Reported wh-question: ask + wh-word + subject + verb.

C2

She asked whether the figures had been verified.

Reported yes/no question: ask + if/whether + subject + verb.

C3

The officer told us to remain outside.

Reported command: tell/ask + object + to-infinitive.

C4

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.

Reported wh-question: ask + wh-word + subject + verb.

C5

She asked whether the figures had been verified.

Reported yes/no question: ask + if/whether + subject + verb.

C6

The officer told us to remain outside.

Reported command: tell/ask + object + to-infinitive.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

why the delivery had been delayed

Reported wh-question requires “why the delivery had been delayed” in this model. ask + wh-word + subject + verb.

D2

whether the figures had been verified

Reported yes/no question requires “whether the figures had been verified” in this model. ask + if/whether + subject + verb.

D3

told us to remain

Reported command requires “told us to remain” in this model. tell/ask + object + to-infinitive.

D4

ask + wh-word + subject + verb

Reported wh-question is built as ask + wh-word + subject + verb.

D5

ask + if/whether + subject + verb

Reported yes/no question is built as ask + if/whether + subject + verb.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.

ask + wh-word + subject + verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended reported wh-question effect.

E2

She asked whether the figures had been verified.

ask + if/whether + subject + verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended reported yes/no question effect.

E3

The officer told us to remain outside.

tell/ask + object + to-infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended reported command effect.

E4

He asked why the delivery had been delayed.

ask + wh-word + subject + verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended reported wh-question effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

He asked why the delivery had been delayed. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses ask + wh-word + subject + verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

She asked whether the figures had been verified. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses ask + if/whether + subject + verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The officer told us to remain outside. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses tell/ask + object + to-infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____